

IELTS Reading Practice

The Pyramid of Cestius

READING PASSAGE

The Pyramid of Cestius

A 2000-year-old pyramid in the city of Rome has been restored by archaeologists.

Though Rome draws tourists from around the world to its many impressive sites, one notable monument there has never attracted nearly as much interest: The Pyramid of Cestius. But why would there be a pyramid in Italy? After the Roman conquest of Egypt in 30 B.C., Egyptian architectural style became the fashion in Rome.

Though obelisks and other monuments inspired by Egypt's great pyramids sprung up around the city, only two actual pyramids are known to have been built. The only one left standing, the Pyramid of Cestius, was designed as the burial pyramid for a Roman politician named Caius Cestius, who ordered that the building work be completed within a period of 330 days.

Construction took place at some point between 18 B.C. and 12 B.C. Cestius' pyramid had a layer of white Carrara marble on the outside and was constructed from brick held together by cement on the inside. One of the things that strikes you when you look at the pyramid is how steep it is, making its shape quite unlike that of typical Egyptian pyramids. This difference could have resulted from inaccurate information sent back to Rome by soldiers who saw the pyramids in person in Egypt. Alternatively, Roman builders could have drawn inspiration from the pyramids in Nubia, a region in present-day northern Sudan and southern Egypt.

At the time of its construction, a strict Roman law prohibited tombs within the city, so the Pyramid of Cestius would have stood in countryside. Rome grew enormously over the next two centuries, and by the 3rd century A.D., the pyramid would have been surrounded by buildings. We also know that in the 3rd century A.D., the Pyramid of Cestius was hidden behind a high wall on the orders of Emperor Aurelian; this likely helped it survive through the centuries, even as other ancient monuments disappeared.

By the Middle Ages, the pyramid was covered in vegetation and dirt, and a popular myth suggested that it might be the tomb of Romulus or Remus, the legendary founders of Rome. Cestius' actual tomb and an inscription identifying the pyramid were not rediscovered until the 1660s, when the pyramid underwent restoration.

During excavations, workers cleared away trees and plants and found two marble bases in front of the pyramid, as well as fragments of bronze statues that once stood on either side. However, they did not find the urn containing Cestius' remains, but they did discover a tunnel, suggesting that robbers might have looted the tomb long ago. Though some features no longer exist, at least the pyramid itself has survived.

Today, the Pyramid of Cestius stands near a busy intersection, making it easy for tourists and residents to overlook its full height of 119 feet. Across the intersection is Pirámide station, located on Line B of the Rome Metro.

In 2011, Japanese entrepreneur Yuzo Yagi, president of Yagi Tsusho Ltd, announced his intention to fund a major renovation of the Pyramid of Cestius. He described it as "an act of gratitude" to Italy, a country that contributed to his company's success. Work began shortly after he signed an agreement with the Special Superintendency for the Archaeological Heritage of Rome, and thanks to his 2-million-euro donation, the project was completed ahead of schedule.

As archaeologist Leonardo Guarnieri explained, officials now conduct tours of the newly renovated pyramid twice a month by reservation. Visitors can walk through a narrow corridor to reach the burial chamber, where they can admire frescoes, including four images of the winged Roman goddess Victoria, as well as vases used for rituals and purification. Some frescoes have disappeared over time, but historical records confirm their existence.

Only one issue remains after the restoration: the white exterior of the Pyramid of Cestius needs to be cleaned regularly due to urban pollution. A team of free-climbers will handle the task to avoid placing scaffolding around the

newly restored monument.

QUESTIONS 1–7

Do the following statements agree with the information given in the reading passage? In boxes 1–7 on your answer sheet, write:

TRUE if the statement agrees with the information **FALSE** if the statement contradicts the information **NOT GIVEN** if there is no information on this

1. The Pyramid of Cestius has always been one of Rome's most popular tourist attractions.
2. The construction of the Pyramid was completed before Cestius' death.
3. In the Middle Ages, people thought an original founder of Rome was buried in the Pyramid of Cestius.
4. Today the height of the Pyramid is something that tourists and residents immediately notice.
5. Japanese businessman Yuzo Yagi was an admirer of both Italian and Egyptian architecture.
6. The restoration of the Pyramid of Cestius, which was funded by Yuzo Yagi, finished earlier than expected.
7. Most of the original frescoes inside Cestius' tomb have survived to this day.

QUESTIONS 8–13

Complete the notes below. Choose **ONE WORD ONLY** from the passage for each answer. Write your answers in boxes 8–13 on your answer sheet.

History of the Pyramid of Cestius

Construction of Cestius' pyramid

- It was made from **8** _____ marble and cement.
- Its **9** _____ is different from the pyramids found in Egypt.
- It was originally built in the **10** _____ as tombs in the city were forbidden.
- Emperor Aurelian ordered that a wall be built around it.

Restoration of Cestius' pyramid in the 1660s

- In the 1660s, some broken **11** _____ were found next to it.
- The **12** _____ inside the tomb suggests that robbers had been there.
- The frescoes show mythological scenes and images of vases.

Restoration of Cestius' pyramid today

- A Japanese businessman paid for its restoration.
- Climbers are helping to remove signs of **13** _____.

ANSWER KEY

1. **NOT GIVEN** — There is no information in the passage about the popularity of the Pyramid of Cestius.
2. **TRUE** — The passage states that Caius Cestius ordered the construction to be completed within a specific time frame.
3. **TRUE** — The passage mentions that a popular myth developed during the Middle Ages.
4. **FALSE** — The passage states that the pyramid's full height of 119 feet may be easily missed by passing tourists and residents.
5. **TRUE** — The passage mentions that Yuzo Yagi announced his intention to help fund the renovation of the pyramid as an act of gratitude towards Italy.
6. **TRUE** — The passage states that the restoration was completed ahead of schedule.
7. **FALSE** — The passage mentions that some of the frescoes have disappeared over time.
8. **brick**
9. **shape**
10. **countryside**
11. **statues**
12. **tunnel**
13. **urban pollution**